

In Jordan Peele's film *Get Out*, the moment that turns the whole story inside out is really quiet and almost casual. Chris stands in the hallway of the Armitage house, suitcase in hand, begging Rose for the car keys so they can escape. She digs through her bag, looks up, and says, "You know I can't give you the keys, right?" Until that second, the film has played as an uneasy but familiar story about a Black boyfriend visiting his white girlfriend's comfortable, liberal family. When she refuses, the mask falls. The scene makes something really clear. The real threat is not open hatred. It's affection that turns out to be ownership. This shift raises a deeper problem. How do you represent a kind of racism that doesn't sound like racism, that looks like admiration and care, and that even insists it's on your side? *Get Out* is not just about obvious bigots. The Armitages praise Black athletes, collect African art, date Black partners, and brag that they would have voted for Obama a third time. Yet their business model depends on using Black bodies as material for white renewal. Peele has said that he wrote the film during the Obama years, when many people insisted that racism was "over" and that calling it out was the real problem. He calls that era the "postracial lie" (Peele).

In a previous essay I used absurdism and Afrofuturism to think about resistance in a capitalist world. With *Get Out*, I turn to a more intimate problem. What happens when racism does not show up as insult or open violence, but as romance, praise, and "inclusion"? I argue that Peele uses horror to solve a representational problem. He shows a form of racism that presents itself as love and progress. To do that, the film puts several ideas into tension: Eduardo Bonilla Silva's "racism without racists," Saidiya Hartman's "afterlife of slavery," bell hooks's belief that "there can be no love without justice," and Sara Ahmed's critique of diversity as institutional self defense (Bonilla Silva; Hartman; hooks; Ahmed). Critics of the film, such as Hannah L. Murray and J. Camille, show how *Get Out* turns the Black body into a site of both desire and control

(Murray; Camille) By putting these voices in conversation with Peele's film, I want to show that *Get Out* is not only a story about a bad family. It's an argument about a society that wants to enjoy Colorness while still owning it.

Peele himself ties *Get Out* to the years of Barack Obama's presidency. In an interview, he explains that the film grew from the feeling that many white Americans treated Obama as proof that the country had moved beyond race, even as subtle racist interactions continued. He describes those years as a time when "we lived in this postracial lie" and says he kept noticing "subtle, seemingly harmless interactions" that showed racism was still active under polite surfaces (Peele). This is exactly the world Chris enters. The Armitages don't shout slurs. Instead, Dean jokes that he would have voted for Obama a third time. The party guests admire Chris's "genetics" and ask if "being Black" is "in fashion." Each comment arrives wrapped in friendliness. Together they create a thick atmosphere of entitlement.

Sociologist Eduardo Bonilla Silva gives me language for this kind of environment. In *Racism Without Racists*, he argues that after the civil rights era, many white Americans stopped thinking of themselves as racist, yet they still support and benefit from a racial order that keeps Black people and people of color at a disadvantage. He calls this "colorblind racism," an ideology that allows people to say "I do not see race" while explaining inequality through culture or individual effort (Bonilla Silva 1–4) A Duke University summary of his work notes that Bonilla Silva shifts attention from "the racists" to "the racism," meaning the systems that quietly reproduce inequality (Duke Sociology).

Seen through his framework, the Armitages become a case study in racism without racists. Dean knows how it looks to have Black servants, so he rushes to frame it as anything but racist. His

Obama joke acts like a shield. As literary scholar Hannah L. Murray points out, he “fulfills clichés of the liberal” by showing both awareness that something could look racist and a quick defense that marks him as enlightened (Murray 8). The effect is that Chris has no actual place to put his discomfort. The family works hard to make sure no one can call them racist. At the same time, they literally own the people around them.

The garden party scene makes this double move very clear. One guest grabs Chris’s arm to feel his muscles. Another tells him that Black is “in fashion.” Someone else compares him to Tiger Woods. The camera lingers on Chris’s face as he tries to smile through each interaction. These aren’t really insults in the usual sense. In fact, many could be missread as admiration. Yet, as a student project on the film argues, they show “negrophilia,” a fascination with Blackness that treats Black people as objects to collect or consume rather than as full subjects (Dualle and Szeker 6). The silent auction that follows confirms this reading. The same people who praised Chris’s body now bid on it. Their affection was kind of some type of market research.

Saidiya Hartman helps link this polite horror to a longer history. In her work on slavery and its legacies, Hartman describes the “afterlife of slavery” as the way the old system continues as skewed life chances and premature death for Black people. A *New Yorker* profile summarizes her idea as the ongoing presence of limited access to health care, education, and safety that raises the question, “Did slavery ever really end?” (Hartman, qtd. in Tolentino). Hartman’s concept insists that slavery isn’t just a past event. It is a structure that actually mutates and survives.

*Get Out* translates that theory into images. The Coagula procedure turns Black people into vessels for wealthy white clients who want better sight, stronger bodies, or artistic talent. J. Camille argues that the film presents “the Black body as a commodity,” inspired by historical

systems like slavery that treated Black people as property (Camille 2) In this sense, the Armitages are not inventing a new form of racism. They are updating an old one. The plantation has become a suburban estate. The auction block has become a bingo game. The logic remains the same. White comfort and longevity rest on Black capture.

If Hartman emphasizes structure, bell hooks asks us to think about intimate relationships. In *All About Love*, hooks writes that “there can be no love without justice,” and that abuse or neglect “negate love” even when the abuser claims to care (hooks 33). For her, love is not just a warm feeling but it’s a daily practice that combines care, commitment, knowledge, and respect. Above all, it actually refuses domination.

Rose and Chris’s relationship becomes more unsettling in light of hooks’s argument. At the start of the film, Rose appears to be the perfect ally partner. She jokes about her father’s predictable Obama line. She stands up for Chris when the police officer wants to see his ID. She frames herself as someone who understands racism and wants to protect him from it. The key scene with the keys reveals the truth. When Chris pleads, she smiles sadly and says, “You know I can’t give you the keys, right?” Her loyalty has never been to Chris’s safety or autonomy. It has always been to her family’s project. She loves the idea of herself as a white woman who dates Black men. She doesn’t love Chris enough to betray the system that makes that identity and her fantasy possible. In hooks’s terms, whatever feelings Rose has do not qualify as love, because they sit on top of a plan to use Chris’s body. They’re an awful commitment to domination, not to justice.

Sara Ahmed’s work on diversity gives another angle on this deception. In *On Being Included*, Ahmed studies how universities and other institutions use the language of “diversity” to manage racism without really changing it. Diversity, she argues, often “is used as evidence that

institutions do not have a problem with racism” (Ahmed 1). A review of her book explains that the word “diversity” has come to replace more direct terms like “antiracism” because it’s kind of vague and less threatening (Roij 2). The Armitages actually behave like a small diversity institution. Their Black servants, their interracial relationships, and their collection of African art all function as proof that they are “inclusive.” Dean even points to how long Georgina and Walter have been “with the family,” as if their loyalty cancels the ugly history of Black domestic labor. As Ahmed might say, these signs of inclusion are used to protect the family from critique. They make it easier to say, “We ain’t not racist, look at our diverse household!” At the same time, they do nothing to question who holds power, who owns the house, or who controls the keys.

Bringing these voices together shows that *Get Out* is staging a conversation about modern racism. Peele dramatizes the “postracial lie” by filling the Armitage home with compliments and cultural references that never disturb white control (Peele). Bonilla Silva gives that pattern a name in “colorblind racism” and “racism without racists” (Bonilla Silva 2) Hartman insists that this is not a new story at all, but the “afterlife of slavery” in a different costume (Hartman, “Lose Your Mother”). Hooks refuses to let us call any of this love. Love without justice, she argues, is just another word for possession (hooks 33; 87). Ahmed warns that even the language of inclusion can become a shield that keeps institutions comfortable rather than changing them (Ahmed 2–3). The film’s critics extend this conversation. Murray thinks the Armitages are some part of a “US Gothic imagination,” where the respectable liberal family hides racial horror under polite manners (Murray 10) J. Camille interprets the Coagula surgery as a “nightmarish version of future American racism,” where Black bodies are sort of like the raw material for white self improvement (Camille 4). Another essay on the film describes how Peele “lays bare and

ridicules” a kind of white liberal paranoia that denies racism while obsessing over it in private, what the author calls a “false assertion of the post racial” (Szczepaniak 5) These scholars help show that the Armitages aren’t actually monsters from nowhere. They are exaggerated images of habits that exist in workplaces, elite campuses, and friend groups.

Thinking with all of these writers changes how I see that quiet hallway scene with the keys. At first it reads as a plot twist. The girlfriend is evil. Once I put Peele in conversation with Bonilla Silva, Hartman, hooks, Ahmed, and the film’s critics, the scene becomes a small model of a bigger structure. Chris is asking for freedom of movement. Rose holds the keys and smiles. She insists that she cares about him, but she cares more about the system that secures her family’s comfort. Her refusal is not only personal betrayal. It’s the moment when liberal affection reveals itself as ownership.

This actually has a lot of stakes beyond one movie. Colorblind racism and the postracial lie continue to show up in institutions that celebrate diversity while defending practices that harm Black people and other people of color. Hartman’s question, “Did slavery ever really end?” reminds us that polite inclusion can coexist with deadly inequality (Hartman, qtd. in Tolentino). Hooks pushes us to measure our relationships, and our institutions, by whether they are willing to give up control for the sake of justice. Ahmed warns us not to accept “diversity” as proof that the work is done. *Get Out* brings these concerns into the space of a horror film and forces them to feel close.

In some way, Peele’s film helps us see that the hardest forms of racism to confront aren’t actually the ones that call themselves racist. They are the ones that say “I love you” while keeping their hand on the keys. The film suggests that real love, and real progress, would require a different

gesture. It would look like handing over control, listening when someone says they are not safe, and refusing to treat people of color as resources for white renewal.